

Stiff competition

6-core processors from Intel and AMD expected in the next couple of months

Medal of Honor

Will use two game engines – UE3 and Frostbite, used in Bad company 2



WD My Book 3.0

Taking the SuperSpeed highway

Western Digital's My Book 3.0 is its foray into tapping the superspeed USB 3.0 standard. My Book 3.0 with a black matte finish has a simplistic design with no screen in the front panel like its My Book Studio and My Book Elite counterparts in the 1 TB segment. There is only one tiny pinhole white indicator in the front. The remaining three edges are surrounded by air vents.

USB 3.0 is the future standard for data transfers

and all the major external drive manufacturers are supporting it. The drive has a power connection port along with a USB 3.0 connection port on the rear. After installing the USB 3.0 drivers from the software CD the device is ready for use.

As expected, the USB 3.0 really enhances data transfer speeds. In the real life tests, it took under 90 seconds for 4 GB file transfers which is unheard of on USB 2.0. This is one of the first few drives of its kind and as expected, it's priced at a hefty Rs. 11,190.

Specifications

Usable capacity: 931.5GB, USB 3.0 interface, 7200 rpm, 32 MB buffer

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Price: Rs. 11,190

6.5/10

Features.....7
Performance 6.5
Build Quality7
Value6

Specifications

40mm neodymium drivers, 32 Ohm impedance, Frequency range: 20Hz to 22kHz, 1.2m cable, noise cancelling -20dB at 200Hz

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Price: Rs. 5,999

6/10

Features.....6.5
Performance3.5
Build Quality7.5
Value6.5

Philips SHN 9500

Bold newcomer to shhh territory

The SHN 9500 is a value offering in noise cancellation, although this isn't apparent from the solid build. Brushed aluminium for the outer cups, strong plastic everywhere, except the slightly flimsy headband fastening on the cups. The mute button works well and will cut off all sound of whatever you are listening to, so you can listen to (for example) someone talking to you. A single AAA battery powers the noise cancelling (NC) circuitry.

NC is decent, because even with no music playing, it takes the bassiness out of intrusive sounds, however it doesn't fully remove ambient sounds like a noisy fan. Sound quality is something that should not be compromised, however, this

is typically a tall order for NC headphones, especially entry-level ones. The SHN 9500 is no exception – quality is very mediocre. The sound staging is congested, instruments do not have that air to them and the sound seems to be coming from inside your head, towards the top. Turning NC on and off also affects sound – with it off, bass notes seem a little tighter. With NC on, the background is a little darker, which is good, and female vocals seem to gain some character and presence. The overall tone of the music is slightly warm, but it's not enjoyable for the discerning. A mixed bundle really, discerning music lovers will not be interested. With slightly boomy bass, this SHN 9500 is better for less critical applications, like movies.



Priced at Rs. 5,999, these are certainly cheaper than what most NC headphones are priced at, moreover they're decidedly upmarket looking. But performance is strictly decent for most users, and a disaster in audiophile terms. If you're looking for "decent" travelling cans, look them up.